

think about their erotic selves as women who could “no longer live outside power in sex” (Hollibaugh 1984, 411). Even more were interested in materialist feminist analyses of the sexual lives of others (Newton and Nestle). And still, some began to chronicle the extent to which theories of our racial selves and national imaginaries subtended our erotic lives altogether.

New work in the field by Lyndon Gill (2018) *Erotic Islands: Art and Activism in the Queer Caribbean* or Jafari Allen (2012) *Black Queer Diaspora* ought to remind us that the terrain of the erotic is under constant revision and reimagining. This work pulls us away from the pleasure/pain binary into experiences that encompass embodiments that are not “human”—I am thinking about Mel Chen’s (2012) work in *Animacies* in particular. In short, how the erotic embraces us is just as important as a *practice* as is our critique of its power.

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Experience

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The feminist movement maxim “The personal is political” underscores the connections between personal experiences and larger sociopolitical structures, but what this means in terms of not just what but *how* we know what we know is less clear. The formula has been understood to mean that our experiences are the wellspring of our most authentic politics, our most authentic truths, but what exactly mediates the movement between personal and structural?

One of the tasks of feminist theories has been to challenge conventional epistemologies—ways of knowing, accumulating, and institutionalizing knowledge—in order to make more obvious that these are not the *only* ways of knowing and that these are often ideological in themselves. Or as Catherine Belsey asks, “To what extent is it possible to perceive the world independently of the conventional ways in which it is represented? To what extent is experience contained by language, society, history?” (1980, 13). The idea that experience comes from authentic knowledge is distilled from multiple liberal humanist traditions that assume a rational actor who can evaluate his interests in relation to others and then arrive at proper and proportionate action. But as many observers note, the problems with this set of premises are multiple. Liberal humanism recognizes some forms of reason and not others (for instance, that reason is the province of certain populations, of which others are insensible or incapable), it assumes that knowledge is a clear expression of an unmediated inner truth, and it assumes that the conditions for acting

upon what “counts” as reason are always available to all persons.

Nonetheless, the language of experience, of seeing (or sensing) as believing, undergirds much western thought. Experience is not a straight path to an ethical or political sensibility, however; thus social movements posit a process through which experience leads to the articulation of a *shared social consciousness*. This understanding is sometimes referred to as *standpoint epistemology*: the notion that a particular social location can yield a unique set of experiences and thus knowledges, related to the earlier Marxist notion that the oppressed classes themselves hold their own comprehensive truths about the world. Standpoint epistemologies held that an externally imposed obstacle—whether understood in liberal humanism as superstition, in Marxist humanism as the alienation of the proletariat from his own labor, or in the feminist theories of Simone de Beauvoir and Nancy Hartsock as a “slave mentality” or the imposition of a “perverse” masculine order—must be overcome to achieve full or true consciousness (Beauvoir [1949] 1989; Hartsock [1983] 2004). Standpoint epistemologies have thus constituted a central ideological formation for modern political and social theory, including those with radical or revolutionary commitments; standpoint insists that we already know what we need to know. However, the woman of color feminisms of the 1970s, 1980s, and 1990s in particular challenged standpoint epistemologies and their limits for how we understand both political education and affiliation. These theorists pointed out that many revolutionary theories and practices still assumed a self-sufficient, self-knowing individual, replicating the subject of western Enlightenment philosophies. Furthermore, they observed that no standpoint can withstand its contradictions; standpoint theories generally flatten out the complicated ways we become *kinds* of people, *kinds* of

subjects. For instance, putting the category of “woman” in the center of feminist theory negated the work of Black, Indigenous, and non-Black women of color in other liberation movements. As Norma Alarcón writes, “The inclusion of other analytic categories [in a feminist theory based solely on gender] such as race and class becomes impossible for a subject whose consciousness refuses to acknowledge that ‘one becomes a woman’ in ways that are much more complex than in a simple opposition to men. In cultures in which ‘asymmetric race and class relations are a central organizing principle of society,’ *one may also ‘become a woman’ in opposition to other women*” (1994, 360; my emphasis).

One of woman of color feminisms’ key insights, then, is that violence may come from men, but it also comes from other women. Some of these violences include regarding race and class as secondary features in social organization or philosophical ontologies and treating the labor of women of color to interpret their experiences as *things* without theorizing their conditions or acknowledging other forms of language—such as Audre Lorde’s poems—as theory too (Lorde [1984] 2007c). Woman of color feminisms have repeatedly observed this conundrum. As early as the 1980s, bell hooks describes the racialized division of labor in women’s studies classrooms between women of color as objects of knowledge—as persons to learn *about*—against white women as agents of knowledge, as persons to learn *from*. In this division, women of color are confined to experience, while white women make theory.

Another strain of feminist theories challenging the nature of experience follows from semiotics and post-structuralism. Thus Joan Scott observes, “The evidence of experience then becomes evidence for the fact of difference, rather than a way of exploring how difference is established, how it operates, how and in what ways it constitutes subjects who see and act in the world” (1992,

25). Scott argues that to invoke experience as evidence masks the “necessarily discursive nature of these experiences” (31). She does not reject experience, however, but asks us to radically *historicize* it. Subjects do not simply acquire experiences that as *possessions* can sediment a subjectivity, an interiority, that gives rise to already-known modes of critique or politics; experience is not a *thing* to be observed that carries inherent value. It is instead a narration that secures the grounds for meaning making.

The point here is to take note of the *effects* of the claim to experience, to be attentive to the *effects* of our own assent to its transparency. Experience as *evidence* can bring some together, but experience as *truth* can exclude others. Where the ontological “truth” of experience rests on assumptions about how categories of being (such as “woman”) should function and therefore generates conjectures (and sometimes condemnations) about how deviations from “true” being are produced, it cannot or will not account for the ways that such measures are made in the first place—and it needs to do so. Observe the trans exclusionary argument that the experience of having certain genitalia binds together a collectivity as “women,” presuming that a specific social consciousness follows from that experience, though that experience is not the same even for all persons with those parts. Or consider that the experience of assault does not guarantee a politics to follow: one survivor might support the expansion of policing, while another calls for its abolition. The epistemological certainty of experience thus presents a bind. Recourse to the experience of everyday harm or extraordinary violation has fueled some of the most dynamic social movements of the last century. But experience can also be limiting where there is an uncritical dimension to its recourse. (“Lived experience” continues to hold sway as a conversation killer, invoked to bring an end to a debate.) Making experience “visible”

might preclude an analysis of the way ideologies actually work to organize categories and produce differences and elide the premises of what these categories and differences mean, how they operate, and even how we feel about them.

What does it mean to say that experience is a product of interpretation, mediated by language and ideology? It means that we have to consider that our politics come into being not through something we *have*—lived experiences as resolute properties of the self—but through something we *do* or come to *want*, through those contacts, attachments, and investments that take form in encounters with power and knowledge. It means putting less faith in experience as a transcendental placeholder for the production of truth or politics and exerting more pressure on the conditions that produce its significance. Does this make the evidence of experience any less valid or powerful as a source for theorizing and for making change? Not at all. When we witness our own experiences, we are not drawing on some core, intrinsic sense of self, but we are speaking to and about ideology, history, reciprocity, and power. Because we cannot assume a common experience will yield a shared politics, Bernice Johnson Reagon (1983) argues that feminism is not a respite from the world but “a coalition,” with all the risk this entails. Similarly, Cathy Cohen calls for a process of movement building “rooted not in our shared history or identity, but in our shared marginal relationship to dominant power that normalizes, legitimizes, and privileges” (1997, 458). Experience is not a fixed point from which one interacts in the world, then, but an ongoing relation with which we might destabilize all our epistemological certainties and through which another world is possible.